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National report submitted pursuant to Human Rights Council resolutions 5/1 and 16/21*

Eswatini

* The present document is being issued without formal editing.

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Introduction

1. Eswatini presents its 4th Cycle Universal Periodic Review (UPR) National Report, which provides updates on measures taken to address the accepted recommendations. The country received 222 recommendations, of which 156 were accepted and 66 noted.

2. Recommendations reported in Eswatini's mid-term UPR report will not be repeated in this report. These recommendations include curbing gender-based violence, improving access to clean water, sanitation and hygiene, and ensuring inclusive access to education.

I. Process for the preparation of the report

3. This report has been prepared under the auspices of the National Mechanism for Reporting and Follow-Up (NMRF) and builds upon activities undertaken in preparing the mid-term report. Pursuant to the submission of the mid-term report, the NMRF Secretariat, in collaboration with the UN Country Office (UNCO) and Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR), convened consultative workshops on 8-9 July and 16 December 2025 for a continuous progress update on the implementation of the UPR Recommendations.

4. To initiate the drafting of the National Report, the NMRF Secretariat issued a call for information to duty bearers to provide written submissions on the progress of outstanding recommendations. On 24-26 March 2026, through the support of the Commonwealth Secretariat, a workshop was convened to strengthen the preparations for the National Report and sharing of best practises.

5. Participants in these consultations were drawn from Government Ministries and Departments, Civil Society Organisations, Non- Government Organisations, and the Commission on Human Rights and Public Administration (CHRPA). These consultations resulted in the compilation of the Draft UPR Report, which was subsequently enhanced through the first stakeholder consultation held on 24 June 2026 and validated on 23 July 2026. The report was then submitted to Cabinet for final endorsement and thereafter deposited with the OHCHR Secretariat.

II. Developments since the last review

6. Eswatini established a Legal Aid office under the Ministry of Justice and Constitutional Affairs in 2023 and has also enacted the Legal Aid Act 11 of 2025 and the Legal Practitioners (Amendment) Act of 2025 to provide for access to justice by providing affordable, accessible and accountable legal aid services to indigent persons upon satisfaction of the means and merits tests. The service of legal representation has not yet been provided by the Legal Aid Office, as the Government is in the process of developing the necessary Regulations to operationalise these Acts. Currently, the services offered by the Legal Aid Office include admission of walk-in clients for advice, referrals, drafting court processes for clients, and mediation where parties consent. Furthermore, the office conducts legal education in sectors identified periodically and upon request by institutions.

7. Since its establishment, the Office has attended to a total of 2066 individuals as shown in the table below (as at 30 June 2026):

Year	*Walk-In Clients*		*Outreach Clients*		*Total*
	F	M	F	M	
2023	27	40	0	0	**67**
2024	153	112	267	309	**841**
2025	161	97	490	280	**1028**
2026	55	75	0	0	**130**
Total	**396**	**324**	**757**	**589**	**2066**

8. Eswatini enacted the Computer Crime and Cyber Crime Act 6 of 2022 and Data Protection Act 5 of 2022 to address offences committed through computer systems and electronic communications networks. The Act promotes and protects human rights by criminalising cyber-related offences, safeguarding privacy and personal data, protecting children from online exploitation, and strengthening cybersecurity. Further, the Acts have enhanced the protection of individuals and institutions from cybercrime, increased confidence in the digital environment, and facilitated the safe enjoyment of rights in the digital space while ensuring that law enforcement powers are exercised in accordance with the Constitution.

9. The establishment of the National Disability Advisory Council in 2023 plays a crucial role in advancing the rights and wellbeing of persons with disabilities. This institution contributes to the effective implementation of the Persons with Disabilities Act 16 of 2018.

III. Implementation of recommendations from the previous cycle

Ratification of international instruments and cooperation with human rights mechanisms (118.11–15, 118.16–21, 118.26, 118.27, 118.28, 118.30, 118.32, 118.37, 118.40, 118.84)

10. The Government affirms that ratification and accession to outstanding treaties remain under active consideration within the national consultative framework, and these include: the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide, Optional Protocol to the Convention Against Torture (OP-CAT), Optional Protocol to Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (OP-CEDAW). The Government further wishes to clarify that the delay in ratification does not reflect a lack of political will, but rather the requirement of broad-based consultations, including with Parliament and civil society.

11. Following the establishment of the NMRF, Eswatini received technical assistance from the OHCHR in collaboration with the UNCO to strengthen its capacity to deliver on its mandate. The following milestones were achieved:

- Disseminated third cycle UPR recommendations and developed the first UPR Recommendations Implementation plan;
- Submitted UPR mid-term report;
- Submitted outstanding initial reports under the ICESCR and CAT and is currently working on the periodic report on CERD;
- Capacitated the NMRF Committee on the National Recommendations Tracking Database;
- The country benefited from the UPR Voluntary Fund in 2024, 2025 and 2026, which assisted in the implementation of some of the UPR recommendations (including the capacitation of the NMRF, development of the Legal Aid Act).

12. Eswatini further received technical assistance from the Commonwealth on better cooperation with international human rights mechanisms, domestication of treaties and strengthening of institutions such as the NMRF, CHRPA, Attorney General’s Office in February 2024, October 2024, December 2025 and March 2026.

13. In cooperation with regional bodies, Eswatini hosted a Promotion Mission of the African Committee of Experts on the Rights and Welfare of the Child in July 2023, the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights in July 2025 and the Network of African National Human Rights Institutions (NANHRI) in June 2026. Eswatini participated in a dialogue with the African Commission on the ratification and domestication of African treaties (including Protocols) on human rights.

14. Eswatini aligned the recommendations emanating from the human rights mechanisms with the relevant Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), the National Development Plan

(2022-2028), and the Government Programme of Action (2023 – 2028), which reinforces coherence between international obligations and national development priorities. Further, the implementation of the SDGs is monitored by the Ministry of Economic Planning and Development, working closely with the SDGs Focal points in line Ministries and ensuring that progress on human rights and the SDGs is tracked comprehensively. It is worth noting that the country participates in the High-Level Political Forum, which reviewed Eswatini's third Voluntary National Review Report on the SDGs in July 2025.

Legal and institutional reforms (118.45, 118.46, 118.48, 118.49, 118.50, 118.51, 118.52, 118.53, 118.54, 118.55, 118.56, 118.57, 118.58, 118.115, 118.116)

15. The Government is expediting efforts towards the enactment of the Commission on Human Rights and Public Administration Bill 2025 and the Leadership Code of Conduct Bill of 2025, which seek to strengthen the mandate, independence, and operational capacity of the Commission on Human Rights and Public Administration. These Bills build on earlier iterations that were subjected to review and modifications over the past years to address emerging human rights standards and ensure consistency with governance frameworks. The Bills were introduced for debate in Parliament in March 2026 and April 2025, respectively.

16. Over the reporting period, the CHRPA continued to strengthen the promotion and protection of human rights through institutional capacity-building, public education, and strategic partnerships. The CHRPA trained more than 2,000 security personnel on human rights-compliant policing, including the lawful use of force, prevention of torture and ill-treatment, ethical conduct, and constitutional safeguards, thereby promoting greater accountability and respect for human rights within law enforcement. It also expanded human rights awareness programmes through community dialogues and outreach initiatives, particularly targeting rural and underserved communities, while enhancing the capacity of traditional leaders to promote human rights and refer violations through appropriate mechanisms. In addition, the CHRPA strengthened collaboration with civil society organisations in implementing human rights programmes, community monitoring, documentation of violations, and advocacy, contributing to a more coordinated, inclusive, and effective national human rights protection system.

17. The Law Reform Unit has updated and revised statutes for the period 2023–2025, conducted research on and developed papers on the definition of reasonable provision under Section 29 (7) (b) and 34 (1) of the Constitution, which will inform law reform initiatives on the Administration of Estates and intestate succession.

18. As part of ongoing efforts to strengthen the independence and efficiency of the Judiciary, members of the Judicial Service Commission were appointed through Legal Notice of 2025. The reconstitution of the Commission has enhanced its capacity to discharge its constitutional mandate, including overseeing the appointment, discipline, and administration of judicial officers.

19. During the reporting period, the Judiciary continued to strengthen the administration of justice through the appointment of additional judicial officers. A total of 4 Superior Courts Judges (2 males and 2 females), 2 Principal Magistrates (both Females), 3 Senior Magistrates (2 males and 1 female), and 12 Ordinary Magistrates (7 males and 5 females) were appointed to augment the existing complement of judicial personnel, improve access to justice, reduce case backlogs, and enhance the timely delivery of judicial services.

20. In fighting corruption, the Anti-Corruption Commission (ACC) established in terms of section 3 of the Prevention of Corruption Act 3 of 2006, is an independent body mandated to prevent and eradicate corruption in all sectors of society. The Government continues to strengthen its institutional capacity and operational independence, and efforts to mobilise adequate resources remain ongoing.

Equality and non-discrimination (118.59, 118.76, 118.71, 118.72, 118.165, 118.170, 118.192, 118.171, 118.166, 118.211, 118.212, 118.213, 118.214, 118.168)

21. While CEDAW has not yet been fully incorporated into domestic law, the Government is progressively aligning national laws with the Convention's provisions.

22. The Government recognises the need to repeal or amend legal provisions that perpetuate gender stereotypes and discrimination against women. To achieve this in a structured and coordinated manner, the Government developed the Programme of Action 2023–2029, which serves as the overarching national development framework. Under objective 5.3 – "Enhance gender and disability mainstreaming and inclusion across all sectors" – all government ministries are directed to review their respective pieces of legislation to promote the objects and purposes of CEDAW.

23. With specific reference to enabling women's enjoyment of fundamental human rights, including the right to property and inheritance, the Government has prioritised the enactment of a suite of Family Law Bills. These include Marriages Bill 8 of 2022, Matrimonial Property Bill 9 of 2022, Draft Administration of Estates (Amendment) 2024, and Bills amending the Wills Act and Intestate Succession Act. Once enacted, these Bills will harmonise existing customary and statutory legal frameworks, eliminate discriminatory provisions that currently limit women's capacity to own, inherit, and administer property, and bring domestic law into closer alignment with CEDAW.

24. To eliminate occupational segregation and ensure equal pay for equal work, Eswatini ratified ILO Conventions Nos. 100 and 111. To domesticate these, the Employment Act 5 of 1980 prohibits discrimination and enshrines equal pay, while the Industrial Relations Act (IRA) 1 of 2000 (as amended) requires employers to adopt non-discrimination policies. The Employment Bill further reinforces gender equality. Compliance is monitored through regular unannounced labour inspections, with persistent violations referred for prosecution. Remuneration discrepancies are not among the most common violations found, indicating general compliance. Nevertheless, the Government continues awareness-raising on gender stereotypes and encourages women's participation in non-traditional sectors through skills development and career guidance programmes, consistent with these recommendations.

25. The Government continues to ensure the protection of persons with albinism (PwA) and PWD. The Persons with Disabilities Act of 2018 and the National Disability Plan of Action (NDPA) 2024–2028 prohibit discrimination against PwA and PWD, requiring all ministries to mainstream disability and albinism-related needs across health, education, justice, and social protection systems. In partnership with stakeholders including the Stukie Foundation and UNFPA, public awareness has been advanced through annual commemorations of International Albinism Awareness Day on 13 June, as well as radio programmes that challenge stigma and promote inclusion. These commemorations integrate skin-health clinics and medical assessments, enabling early detection of skin cancer and other conditions. Visibility of the rights and needs of PwA has increased, coordination among Government and civil society has improved, and access to health services has expanded.

26. Regarding PWD, the NDPA 2024–2028 provides a coordinated national framework to advance the rights, inclusion, and dignity of PWD. Key achievements include the establishment of a multi-stakeholder national coordination mechanism, a costing and financing dialogue for disability-inclusive programming, and the integration of disability indicators into the Education Management Information System (EMIS), with over 500 education officers trained to improve identification and reporting of learners with disabilities.

27. Social protection coverage has expanded, with disability grant beneficiaries increasing from 14,802 to 17,500 in the 2024/25 fiscal year. Measures to reduce stigma and discrimination have focused on awareness-raising, disability mainstreaming within public institutions, and community engagement, underpinned by national handbooks and rights-based advocacy. Public events have been leveraged as strategic platforms for social change, including job and entrepreneurship expos for PWD, music and art festivals, and participation in national cultural events such as Umhlanga Reed Dance, Emaganu, and Incwala, all used

to promote positive narratives and create opportunities for networking, skills development, and market access for PWD.

28. Regarding discrimination based on sexual orientation and gender identity, the constitutional guarantee of equality before the law applies to all persons. The Government continues to engage with stakeholders to ensure that all individuals are protected from violence and discrimination. There have been no reported cases of people being violated or abused on the basis of their sexual orientation.

Human rights and climate change (118.197)

29. On the participation of vulnerable groups in climate change and disaster risk reduction, National Determined Contributions (NDC) 3.0 adopts an inclusivity and Just Transition approach, with dedicated targets for women, youth, and PWDs in climate governance bodies, alongside measures to remove participation barriers such as transport costs. The Ministry of Tourism and Environmental Affairs, in collaboration with DPMO, convened a Gender and Climate Change Integration Indaba to co-design gender-responsive and youth-inclusive actions for NDC 3.0.

30. A child-centred process enabled children and youth to develop recommendations and present them directly to policymakers through a Youth Consultation Forum. The NDC 3.0 process also strengthened protection for refugees and internally displaced persons, with commitments to develop inclusive multi-hazard early warning systems ensuring participation of women, children, and PWDs. The Disaster Risk Management Act 16 of 2025 was enacted through multi-sectoral stakeholder consultations, establishing a proactive, inclusive disaster risk framework.

Prohibition of torture and ill-treatment (118.79, 118.88, 118.89, 118.117, 118.110)

31. Eswatini's Constitution outlaws torture and ill-treatment of persons. Section 18 prohibits inhuman or degrading treatment, while Section 38(e) designates freedom from torture as non-derogable. Section 57(3) explicitly prohibits law enforcement officials from engaging in, encouraging, or tolerating torture under any circumstances.

32. These constitutional provisions are incorporated in the Correctional Services Act 13 of 2017, Police Service Act 22 of 2018, and Umbutfo Eswatini Defence Force Order 10 of 1977 (as amended). Complaints are investigated through Internal Complaints and Discipline Units or Panels of Enquiry. Eswatini does not have a specific torture law, but acts of torture are also prohibited under various pieces of legislation such as the Children Protection and Welfare Act 6 of 2012. The Commissions of Enquiry Act 35 of 1963 empowers investigations, with perpetrators referred for prosecution. The Inquests Act 59 of 1954 ensures transparent investigation of deaths in custody, and no deaths in detention were reported between 2021–2025.

Complaints against Police (2021–2025)

Year	*Hhohho*	*Manzini*	*Shiselweni*	*Lubombo*	*Total*
2021	7 (4M,3F)	2 (M)	0	1 (M)	10
2022	4 (2M,2F)	4 (M)	0	0	8
2023	1 (M)	2 (M)	0	0	3
2024	7 (M)	1 (M)	0	1 (M)	9
2025	1 (M),1 (F)	2 (M)	2 (M)	1 (M),1 (F)	8
Total					**38**

33. Most complaints involved assaults during arrests. Disciplinary measures were instituted against officers; those found guilty were given various punishments, such as redeployment and admonishment. Worth noting is that regular analysis of complaints is

performed to identify trends, and the findings are used to inform management for corrective actions and capacity strengthening.

34. The Police Academy, in partnership with CHRPA, trained 353 officers between 2023-2026.

Year	*Males*	*Females*
2023	55	18
2024	59	15
2025	129	33
2026	26	18
Total	**269**	**84**

35. A Police Science programme with Human Rights Law, administered with the University of Eswatini, benefited 86 officers.

Year	*Males*	*Females*	*Total*
2018 - 2021	21	6	27
2020 - 2023	5	5	10
2022 - 2025	18	9	27
2025 - 2027	11	11	22
Grand Total	**55**	**31**	**86**

36. Additionally, 1,189 officers received refresher courses with human rights components.

Course	*Females*	*Males*	*Total*
Basic Recruit 2022/2023	242	349	591
Basic Recruit 2023/2025	71	120	191
In-service (2023-2026)	150	257	407
Grand Total			**1,189**

37. In relation to investigations on the use of force during the June 2021 Civil Unrest, the Government assessed the events, including the operational response of law enforcement agencies. The circumstances on the ground resulted in casualties while these agencies were restoring public order, protecting lives, and safeguarding public and private property from widespread acts of violence, looting, arson, and vandalism.

38. In addition, the REPS undertook internal investigations and reviews of incidents involving the use of force during the unrest. These processes examined the circumstances surrounding law enforcement operations, including compliance with applicable laws, standard operational procedures, and rules governing the use of force.

39. The outcome of these reviews did not reveal evidence of unlawful conduct on the part of police officers in the discharge of their duties. The findings indicated that the measures employed were directed at restoring public order and preventing further loss of lives and destruction of property, and were considered necessary and proportionate in the circumstances prevailing at the time.

Conditions of detention and arbitrary arrests (118.93, 118.94, 118.95, 118.96)

40. His Majesty's Correctional Services (HMCS) continues to improve detention conditions through infrastructure upgrades. Matsapha Correctional Centre is undergoing major refurbishment, including the construction of modern accommodation designed to meet

accessibility standards for persons with disabilities. Similar accessibility improvements, including the construction of ramps, are planned for Manzini Remand and Mbabane Correctional Centres, with gradual rollout to all correctional facilities.

41. To address overcrowding, the Judiciary has expanded the use of non-custodial sentences, while HMCS continues to implement the Extra-Mural Penal Employment (EPE) Programme, enabling eligible offenders to serve part of their sentences outside correctional facilities under supervision. Further, in 2025 the Prerogative of Mercy released more than 400 offenders, while over 2,000 offenders benefited from sentence reductions.

42. The CHRPA conducts annual assessments of pre-trial detention to identify and address causes of prolonged detention. Measures by the HMCS such as expedited trials, legal aid services and bail reviews have contributed to reducing the number of remand detainees.

43. The table below illustrates the Capacity and Population of Correctional Centres (As at 30 June 2026).

Correctional Centre	*Approved Capacity*	*Inmate Population*
Matsapha Correctional Centre	400	1,212
Mawelawela Correctional Centre	120	270
Big Bend Correctional Centre	350	490
Nhlangano Correctional Centre	200	435
Mbabane Correctional Centre	400	434
Piggs Peak Correctional Centre	400	325
Malkerns Young Persons (MYP) Correctional Centre	150	100
Vulamasango Correctional Centre	300	224
Criminal Correctional Centre	20	25
Manzini Remand Centre	350	526
Bhalekane Correctional Centre	350	351
Mankayane Correctional Centre	50	66
Total	**3,090**	**4,458**

44. HMCS is finalising a Rehabilitation and Reintegration Policy to standardise rehabilitation programmes, strengthen alternatives to imprisonment, promote successful reintegration of offenders into society, reduce recidivism, and align correctional practices with international human rights standards.

45. On combating arbitrary arrests and ensuring fair trials, Section 16 of the Constitution prohibits arbitrary arrest and detention, permitting deprivation of liberty only in accordance with the law. Section 21 guarantees a fair trial within a reasonable time, preventing unlawful detention. Section 22 protects against arbitrary searches. Section 30 of the Criminal Procedure and Evidence Act 66 of 1938 requires that persons arrested without a warrant be produced before a court within 48 hours, unless impractical (e.g., weekend arrests).

Freedom of opinion and expression and access to information, peaceful assembly (118.98, 101,102, 105, 107, 108, 110, 111, 112, 114, 118, 220, 222)

46. Section 24 of the Constitution guarantees freedom of expression and opinion, while Section 25 guarantees peaceful assembly and association. Restrictions under Sections 24(3) and 25(3) must be prescribed by law and justifiable in a democratic society. Eswatini provides a safe environment for exercising civic space rights, with no individuals targeted. Section 60(2) recognises NGOs in the promotion and protection of human rights.

47. The media landscape is diverse, with outlets publishing critical views without censorship or reprisals, complemented by vibrant online discourse. In Prime Minister of

Eswatini and Another v Maseko and Others (73/2016) [2024] SZSC 88 (13 August 2024), the Supreme Court upheld the Sedition and Subversive Activities Act 46 of 1938 and Suppression of Terrorism Act 3 of 2028 as consistent with constitutional guarantees, affirming that rights are subject to lawful limitations in a democratic society.

48. Eswatini convened Sibaya on 23 October–3 November 2023, a national dialogue that is inclusive of all stakeholders, including those critical of the Government policies and actions. Section 232 of the Constitution establishes Sibaya as the highest policy and advisory council, affording every citizen the opportunity to contribute to national development.

49. The successful Sibaya allowed citizens to engage directly with the leadership of the country, with recommendations integrated into the Government Programme of Action (2023–2029). Following this demonstration of stability, Eswatini was removed from the SADC Organ Troika's Agenda in August 2024.

Human Trafficking and contemporary forms of slavery (118.90, 118.91, 118.92)

50. The Government allocates annual budgets under the Prime Minister's Office to implement the National Strategic Framework and Action Plan to Combat People Trafficking 2019-2023 across all pillars, supplemented by departmental budgets and development partner collaboration.

51. The Task Force against Trafficking in Persons has been strengthened through enhanced multi-agency coordination, comprising the Department of Labour, the National Children's Services Department (NCSD), the DSW, the Department of Immigration, the Attorney General's Chambers, the Director of Public Prosecutions (DPP), and REPS. A specialised Protection Committee and Tripartite Mechanism oversee victim identification, risk assessment, referrals, and placement services in line with the People Trafficking and People Smuggling (Prohibition) Act 7 of 2009.

Right to participation in public affairs (118.121, 118.125, 118.196, 118.199, 118.201, 118.198, 118.202)

52. The Elections and Boundaries Commission (EBC) is established by Section 90 of the Constitution and the Elections and Boundaries Commission Act No. 3 of 2013, which stipulates its independence, mandate and composition. The EBC's functions include overseeing and supervising the registration of voters; ensuring fair and free elections; and reviewing the boundaries of tinkhundla areas (constituencies) for purposes of elections.

53. To strengthen participation in public affairs and decision-making processes, the EBC conducts civic and voter education programmes targeting diverse segments of the population through different platforms. These include community and relevant stakeholder outreach meetings, national events such as *Umhlanga, Lusekwane* and *Buganu* ceremonies targeting girls, boys and women respectively. The EBC also reaches the public through the international trade fair, regional career expos, national commemorations such as the International Day of PWDs and other public events. Further, the EBC utilises social media platforms and other digital communication channels to disseminate voter education materials, electoral information and updates, thereby expanding access to information, particularly among young people. All these platforms provide opportunities to engage on the importance of civic participation, voter registration and pursuing leadership positions.

54. In the 2023 General elections, efforts to meet the 30 per cent quota as contemplated under the Constitution have resulted in women holding 29 per cent of seats in the Parliament, with 25% held in the Cabinet. Four women were elected to Parliament under the mechanism provided by the Election of Women Members to the House of Assembly Act 2018, further advancing women's representation in the national decision-making.

55. The table below shows statistics of the proportion of women in decision-making positions in the civil service (as at 30 June 2026):

Cadre	*Total Filled Positions*	*Male*	*Female*	*Male %*	*Female %*	*Data Notes*
Minister	**20**	**15**	**5**	**75.0%**	**25.0%**	**All 20 ministerial positions are filled.**
Principal Secretary	20	12	8	60.0%	40.0%	All 20 positions are filled.
Under Secretary	24*	16	13	55.2%	44.8%	*MTAD has 5 US of which 4 serve as RSs, MoNR&E (2), MoE&T (2), MoPS (2). MoF's position is "vacant" and excluded.
Directors & Equivalent	94**	38	56	40.4%	59.6%	**Includes all "Director," "Commissioner," "Chief," "Registrar," etc. Two "vacant" posts in MoSCYA excluded.
Deputy Directors & Equivalent	35***	18	17	51.4%	48.6%	***Includes "Deputy Director," "Dep. Commissioner," "D.DPP," "AAG," etc.
Programme Managers	59****	25	34	42.4%	57.6%	**** This figure is based on listed posts for Heads of Units and programmes.

56. In the Public Enterprises sector, women are underrepresented in CEO positions (28.3%) but hold a majority of CFO positions (53.2%). The table below shows statistics of women in decision-making positions in Public Enterprises (as at 30 June 2026).

Cadre	*Total Filled Positions*	*Male*	*Female*	*Male %*	*Female %*	*Data Notes*
Chief Executive Officer (CEO)	46	33	13	71.7%	28.3%	3 vacancies excluded (Eswatini Medical Christian University, Eswatini Electricity Company, Eswatini Roads Authority).
Chief Financial Officer (CFO)	47	22	25	46.8%	53.2%	2 vacancies excluded (Eswatini Higher Education Council, Eswatini Roads Authority).

Violence against women (118.61, 118.164, 118.169, 118.176, 118.173, 118.181, 118.183, 118.185, 118.186, 118.187, 118.189, 118.193, 118.194, 118.195, 118.178, 118.182, 118.210, 118.188, 118.179, 118.175, 118.180, 118.190, 118.208, 118.184, 118.191)

57. As reported in the mid-term report, the Government continues to implement the discussed initiatives to reduce the incidence of violence against women.

58. The DPMO has adopted a formalised Gender-Based Violence (GBV) Coordination Mechanism, which provides a guide for improved effectiveness in prevention and response

by establishing common processes and ensuring greater accountability and partnership among all stakeholders.

59. At the national level, the coordination structures include the High-Level Task Force on Violence (HLTFV), composed of Principal Secretaries from key government ministries, which operates at the policy level to provide oversight and policy direction on violence response. The Director's Forum on Violence (DFV) and the Multisectoral Technical Team on Violence (MTTV) consist of technical experts from government ministries, civil society organisations, faith-based organisations, and the traditional sector. At the regional level, four Regional Networks on Violence (RNV), similarly composed, operate across the four regions of the country. These task teams convene quarterly to deliberate on and report on all cases of GBV and violence against children, ensuring systematic information sharing and coordinated responses.

60. With respect to training for law enforcement, educators, and medical personnel, the Government has rolled out continuous capacity-building programmes for frontline responders, including police officers, prosecutors, magistrates, social welfare officers, and healthcare workers. Victim support services have been expanded through the establishment of one-stop centres and referral pathways, while accountability for perpetrators of violence is being pursued through the justice system, including the designation of specialised courts and fast-tracking of GBV cases.

61. Vulnerable women, including survivors of gender-based violence, are supported through the construction of houses, provision of agricultural inputs, and facilitation of business start-ups. This practice aims to reduce dependency on state support while equipping women with sustainable livelihood skills.

62. For survivors of gender-based violence specifically, the Government with the European Union and United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), implements the Hlonipheka Thriving for Dignity Programme, which provides psychosocial support, counselling, and access to economic, educational, and medical services.

63. The Government has also identified and partnered with civil society organisations to host safe spaces, including FLAS, Kwakha Indvodza, the Moya Centre, and Sight of Hope. Women supported under this programme receive employability training in handicrafts, catering, curriculum vitae and proposal writing, and other technical skills, with graduation ceremonies recognising their achievements.

64. Currently, five safe houses are operational across the country, all of which are privately operated under the oversight and technical guidance of the Government. These shelters work in close collaboration with the DSW to provide emergency accommodation, counselling, legal referrals, and reintegration support. Furthermore, the Government is making efforts to establish a state-owned gender-based violence shelter.

Advancement of women (118.163, 118.200, 118.203, 118.204)

65. The Micro, Small and Medium Enterprise (MSME) Unit under the Ministry of Commerce, Industry and Trade is leading reforms to formalise the informal economy and create sustainable employment pathways. The National MSME Policy 2024–2029 promotes the formalisation of informal enterprises (mostly run by women) through simplified registration, improved compliance systems, and enhanced access to finance, markets, and business development services. This Policy enables unemployed citizens, including women and youth, to transition into entrepreneurship and structured economic participation.

66. Further, the Citizen Economic Empowerment (CEE) Act 2023 promotes MSME development and growth through the economic empowerment of citizen-owned companies. The MSME Unit facilitates MSME participation in public procurement and value chains, integrating informal operators into formal economic systems. A tailored financing model has been developed to improve access to credit for MSMEs by providing structured support for start-ups, working capital, and business expansion. This model has reduced lending risks for financial institutions, thereby increasing the availability of loans and allowing more businesses to expand. Consequently, enterprises have created sustainable employment

opportunities, particularly for youth and women, directly contributing to job creation across key sectors of the economy.

Right to social security (118.128, 118.131)

67. The National Social Security Policy (NSSP) of 2021 explicitly endorses ILO Recommendation No. 202 on social security floors and Sustainable Development Goal 1.3. In 2024/2025, the Government introduced a Social Security Inquiry tool used to map existing social protection schemes, assess benefit adequacy, and identify policy gaps and opportunities, particularly among informal economy workers. The tool also provides a mechanism for monitoring implementation of the NSSP.

68. The Ministry of Labour and Social Security conducted a snapshot survey of the informal sector, highlighting that most informal business owners are family breadwinners with limited access to credit and savings, and that social security coverage is minimal, with funeral cover being the most common benefit. These findings underscore the urgency of inclusive social protection frameworks.

69. In 2025, the Government tabled the Eswatini National Pension Fund (ENPF) Bill, introducing a comprehensive National Pension Scheme that expands ENPF's mandate from an employer-employee scheme to a national defined-benefit scheme covering all economically active persons, including informal sector and self-employed workers historically excluded from formal retirement savings.

70. The expanded Older Persons Grant provides predictable income security, reducing poverty and vulnerability among the elderly. Free geriatric healthcare, chronic disease management, and mobile clinics have expanded access to essential services, particularly in rural areas. Additionally, measures introduced under the draft National Social Assistance Policy of 2026 will strengthen protection for vulnerable persons.

71. The National Dynamic Social Registry will improve accuracy and reduce exclusion errors under various social protection grants provided by government, while enhancing timely payments and grievance mechanisms.

72. The decent shelter programme was launched in 2023 with financial support from development partners and the private sector, in collaboration with the NDRMA. The table below shows the number of houses constructed across all regions.

Houses constructed					*Houses rehabilitated*	*Total*
Year	**1 room**	**2 rooms**	**Multiple rooms**	**Total**		
2023/24	21	21	1	43	328	371
2024/25	19	37	3	59	199	258
2025/26	42	62	8	102	302	404
Total	**82**	**110**	**12**	**204**	**829**	**1033**

73. During the period under review, the following programmes were implemented to improve the quality of life for vulnerable groups:

- In 2025, the scholarship allowance (stipend) for Government-sponsored tertiary students was increased by 25 per cent from E1,600 (USD100) to E2,000 (USD125) per month.
- Under the Food Assistance programme, Government fed 263,090 emaSwati from 58,201 households with development partner support.
- A total of 19,436 orphans and vulnerable children were enrolled in the Education Grant Programme.

- Elderly Grant increased by 20 per cent from E500 (USD31.25) to E600 (USD37.50) per month, with the number of beneficiaries increasing from 75 481 in 2021 to 87 861 in 2025.
- The Disability Grant beneficiaries increased from 5 019 in 2021 to 17,193 in 2025, whereby the grant amount increased by 60%, reaching E450 (USD28) per month.
- About 85 elderly funeral assistance claims were processed in 2025, totalling E255,000 (USD14,000).

Human rights and poverty (118.130, 118.132, 118.133, 118.43, 118.134, 118.135, 118.133)

74. The government implemented various measures aimed at reducing the poverty rate. The Eswatini Household Income and Expenditure Survey 2023/24 shows the national poverty rate declined from 58.9% (2016/17) to 53.5%. The poverty gap declined from 24.9% to 21.5%, and the poverty severity index from 13.0% to 10.9%, indicating that the living conditions of the poorest individuals improved and that extreme deprivation became less pronounced.

75. The Government developed the Government Programme of Action (PoA) 2024-2028 alongside the National Development Plan (NDP) 2023-2028 to move beyond the 2018–2023 roadmap. The NDP prioritises poverty reduction, food security, and inclusive economic growth. Both frameworks are designed to drive economic recovery and inclusive growth, with a strong emphasis on reducing disparities across society. Further, the Government has expanded social protection measures targeting vulnerable groups by fully operationalising One-Stop Business Facilitation Centres and streamlining business registration processes for local MSMEs, among other measures. To attract foreign direct investment, particularly in manufacturing and renewable energy, Special Economic Zones (SEZs) continue to offer 20-year corporate tax exemptions and duty-free imports.

76. During the reporting period, the Regional Development Fund (RDF) supported 107 agricultural projects to enhance productivity and food security. These projects included provision of tractors and farm implements, cattle feedlots, poultry and piggery facilities, goat production, fencing and irrigation systems. A total of 2,161 community members directly benefited, with more than 60 per cent being women. The total value of these projects amounts to E126,694,250.21. These efforts are reinforced by the operationalization of Tinkhundla Service Centres, which bring essential government services, such as civil registration and business permits closer to rural communities, significantly reducing geographic disparities and travel costs.

77. Furthermore, the Eswatini Agricultural Development Fund (EADF), launched in 2023, provides agricultural financing products, input subsidies, infrastructure development and resource management. Since its establishment, the EADF has issued 64 direct loans benefiting 79 emaSwati, with total disbursement of E42.7 million, including fees and guarantees. Seventy-five beneficiaries have been supported under the Hamba Ubuye programme with E5 million, enabling cultivation of 487.24 hectares. The Fund has also absorbed initiation fees and management charges amounting to nearly E4.9 million, easing financial burdens on farmers.

78. The Youth Enterprise Revolving Fund approved loans worth over E4.5 million to beneficiaries in 2025, with E3.4 million already disbursed. A mentorship platform was established pairing experienced business mentors with youth entrepreneurs. The Government established regional arts centres and a recording studio to decentralise services. The Eswatini National Youth Council trained 115 youth on curriculum vitae development to improve their employability. The Eswatini Youth Employment Opportunities Project (EYEOP), supported by the World Bank and launched in 2025, aims to tackle youth unemployment through skills training, particularly in agriculture value chains, and entrepreneurship support, complementing the existing Eswatini Youth Empowerment Programme.

79. The National Financial Inclusion Strategy (2023–2028) is expanding access to formal economic participation, especially for workers in the informal sector. Reforms within the

Eswatini Post and Telecommunications Corporation are reducing data costs, ensuring that digital tools become more accessible to rural entrepreneurs.

80. The Government has also strengthened women's economic empowerment through targeted programmes enhancing participation in business and value chains. Capacity-building initiatives, implemented with development partners, provide rural women with entrepreneurial, technical and financial literacy skills in agriculture, agro-processing, small-scale manufacturing, and clean energy. These measures have contributed to increased business formalisation, improved productivity, and expanded market access, thereby reducing poverty and combating hunger in line with the Sustainable Development Goals.

Data collection and research (118.47)

81. Eswatini, through the Central Statistical Office (Statistics Office), has undertaken legislative, institutional and operational measures aimed at enhancing the national data systems. The Statistics Office is reviewing the Statistics Act 14 of 1967 to ensure that the legislative framework governing official statistics remains responsive to modern statistical requirements and in line with international best practices. A revised Statistics Bill has been formulated to establish a modern legal and institutional framework for statistical operations, enhance collaboration among government institutions, and promote data accessibility and confidentiality.

82. In addition, the Statistics Office adopted the Eswatini Strategy for the Development of Statistics (ESDS) 2026-2028 with the objective of aligning statistical priorities with national development goals and international reporting obligations, particularly the SDGs. The Strategy will guide the implementation of activities aimed at strengthening the effectiveness and responsiveness of the national statistical system.

83. The Statistics Office continues to prioritise the production of reliable, timely and disaggregated data (by gender, age, regions, etc) through the regular implementation of national surveys and censuses that support evidence-based policymaking, monitoring and evaluation of national development programmes.

84. Household surveys, including the Eswatini Household Income and Expenditure Survey (EHIES), the Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey (MICS), and agricultural surveys provide critical information on poverty, living conditions, health, education, food security and agricultural production.

85. Key economic analyses conducted periodically include the Consumer Price Index (CPI), Quarterly Producer Price Index (PPI), tourism and accommodation surveys, and other macroeconomic indicators that inform national planning, economic analysis and SDG reporting.

86. The Government has completed phase 1 for the 2027 national Population and Housing Census; phase 2 is ongoing, which is expected to improve the availability and quality of demographic, social and economic data required for inclusive national development planning. Preparatory work is similarly underway for the 2026 Economic Census, which will provide comprehensive information on the structure and performance of the national economy and further strengthen policy formulation and development planning.

Right to health

Measures to prevent HIV/AIDS (118.73, 118.127, 118.145, 118.142, 118.144, 118.152)

87. Eswatini is implementing comprehensive HIV prevention measures, including the provision of free oral and long-acting pre-exposure prophylaxis, as well as post-exposure prophylaxis services for individuals at high risk. The country is among the first in Africa to introduce long-acting injectable prevention options. In addition, targeted HIV testing strategies and programmes for adolescent girls, young women, and key populations integrate biomedical, including condom distribution, behavioural, and structural interventions to address heightened vulnerability.

88. Eswatini has committed to reducing the extent of HIV stigma and discrimination biennially through the Stigma Index, which informs the levels of stigma and discrimination in the country.

89. Community and Health System Interventions:

- The Ministry of Health, with partners, mandated "Sensitivity and Stigma Reduction" training for nurses and clinicians. "Self-stigma" counselling is now integrated into Antiretroviral therapy initiation.
- In 2022/2023, guidelines were updated to strictly emphasise client-led referral (the patient approaches their contacts) rather than provider-led tracing without consent.
- Introduction of Network of "Expert Clients" (people living with HIV who are stable on treatment and volunteer at clinics). These individuals serve as peer counsellors, dismantling the "sick role" associated with HIV and demonstrating that people with HIV can be healthy and productive.
- Campaigns and other initiatives use radio and social media to normalise HIV as a chronic, manageable condition, similar to hypertension or diabetes.

90. As a result of administrative and policy measures implemented to attain adequate standards of health, life expectancy rates have increased to 64.5 years (2026) for both sexes combined from 58.2 years in 2021.

Managing Non-Communicable Diseases (118.139, 118.140, 118.141)

91. Eswatini adopted key policy and regulatory frameworks, including the National Non Communicable Diseases, Injuries and Mental Health (NCDIMH) Sector operational plan 2024-2028, second version of the NCDIMH clinical guidelines, WHO Package of Essential Non-Communicable Disease Interventions (WHO-PEN Plus) protocols, and a Mental Health Decentralization Framework, National Acceleration Plan to Stop Obesity (2024-2028), Cervical Cancer Elimination Strategy (2024-2028).

92. Further, the Ministry is in the process of repealing the Tobacco Control and Nicotine Products Act 16 of 2013 to address the novel tobacco products. The National Nuclear and Radiation Safety Regulatory Act 2025 was enacted. These frameworks provide standardised guidance to expand services from tertiary facilities to primary health care levels.

93. To strengthen governance and coordination, national technical working groups and coordination mechanisms were established and regularly convened, including the Tobacco Control National Coordination Mechanism and PEN Plus taskforce meetings. International collaboration and knowledge exchange were also enhanced through participation in global tobacco control conventions and benchmarking meetings on advanced NCD care models.

94. Capacity strengthening of the health workforce has been prioritised. During the reporting period, 317 healthcare workers were trained on WHO-PEN guidelines, 63 facilities received in-service training on NCD management, and 210 community health workers were capacitated to deliver risk factor education and community-based interventions.

95. Additionally, mental health service capacity was expanded through the training of nurses using the Mental Health Desk Guide and development of a suicide prevention work plan for key populations. Efforts were also made to improve infrastructure and equipment availability across regions. These included distribution of vital sign monitors, HbA1c analysers, fundoscopy cameras, slit lamps, and computers to improve diagnostic and treatment capacity at decentralised facilities. Community outreach programs targeted vulnerable groups such as school children, elderly persons, refugee populations, traditional healers, faith-based communities, and remote rural populations through screening, awareness campaigns, and health education activities.

96. Screening and service delivery have expanded substantially in 2025/2026:

- Over 10,710 school children, 8,835 community members, 4,390 workplace participants, and 2,615 faith-based organisation members were reached through awareness and screening initiatives.
- Outreach screening campaigns reached refugee communities, elderly populations, and rural communities, screening hundreds of individuals for hypertension and diabetes.
- About 57,820 clients were seen for hypertension services and 13,821 clients for diabetes care.
- Hypertension screening coverage reached 85% of clients attending outpatient departments.
- Treatment initiation for hypertension increased to 77%, and blood pressure control reached 68%.
- Diabetes treatment initiation reached 79%, demonstrating improvements in early management of diagnosed cases.
- HPV vaccination launched in 2023 for girls 09–14 yrs (single dose Gardasil 4), total cumulative National HPV vaccination at 60,123 which is 74% of the overall 90% targeted coverage.
- Instituted new cervical cancer screening modalities such as HPV MRNA testing, Visual using acetic acid, Pap smear, Cervical Cancer screening at 68% according to Steps survey 2024.

97. Eswatini continues to maintain policies supporting universal access to essential health services, particularly primary healthcare and priority NCDIMH services. Preventive services such as community-based screening, health education, and awareness campaigns are provided free of charge to the population.

98. The government, through partnerships with international organisations including WHO, CHAI, Taiwan ICDF, and the World Diabetes Foundation, has expanded access to screening services and essential treatment commodities. Support from the Life for a Child programme has enhanced access to insulin, glucometers, testing strips, and cold chain infrastructure for individuals living with Type 1 diabetes. The Ministry of Health developed an Integrated Chronic Disease Management (ICDM) Framework and is currently piloting the model in 12 primary level facilities. The integration of NCDIMH screening into other public health outreach services such as immunisation campaigns, HIV events, and community health days has further strengthened universal access to preventive services.

99. The programme also strengthened surveillance and monitoring through regular data review meetings and operational research initiatives on mental health service access. Community awareness campaigns, school-based interventions, workplace wellness programmes, and faith-based outreach initiatives were implemented to address behavioural and metabolic risk factors.

Sexual Reproductive Health[1] Rights (SRHR) (118.146, 118.148, 118.147)

100. The Ministry of Health was allocated E3.24 billion budget in 2026/2027, an allocation that underscores commitments to strengthening hospitals and clinics, expanding preventive services, and improving access to care. Indirectly, these measures enhance resources required to reduce maternal mortality and morbidity.

101. To accelerate efforts in reducing maternal and neonatal mortality, the Ministry of Health has prioritised high-impact interventions under the Sexual Reproductive Maternal & Newborn Child, Adolescent Health & Nutrition (SRMNCAH&N) Strategy (2024–2028). This Strategy aims to end preventable deaths among women, newborns, children, and adolescents, ensure health and wellbeing across the SRMNCAH&N continuum and create an enabling environment for high-impact interventions.

102. Emergency Obstetric and Newborn Care (EmONC and BEmONC) has been rolled out to all maternity facilities, including private, public, and mission hospitals. Antenatal care

(ANC) coverage remains high at 99%, with skilled birth attendance increasing from 88% (MICS 2014) to 93.4% (MICS 2022), and institutional deliveries rising from 87.7% to 92.7% over the same period. Clinical guidelines for neonatal care and ANC were developed in 2018–2019, complemented by the construction and rehabilitation of maternity wings at the National Referral Hospital, including a maternity theatre and neonatal ICU. The country adopted the WHO recommendation of eight ANC contacts, with emphasis on early booking before 12 weeks gestation, and established Kangaroo Mother Care in all delivery facilities for preterm and low-birth-weight infants.

103. Further, Eswatini advanced elimination of mother-to-child transmission (EMTCT) of HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B, achieving uptake coverage above 95% and reducing final transmission to 1.5% (SRH and HIV Annual Report 2024). Community Health Workers and Rural Health Motivators have been instrumental in sensitising households on maternal danger signs, early booking, and neonatal care, ensuring timely referrals. Postnatal care guidelines were introduced in 2024, and neonatal ICUs and specialised staff have been deployed to strengthen quality of care.

104. Eswatini does not criminalise abortion in cases of rape, incest, serious fetal malformation, or risks to the health or life of the pregnant woman. Through legislation and health policies, the country guarantees access to sexual and reproductive health services without discrimination or consent barriers. The SRMNCAH&N Strategy integrates comprehensive SRH services, including family planning, post-abortion care, GBV response, infertility management, and reproductive cancer screening. Supported by state funding and development partners, community sensitisation campaigns and service delivery reforms continue to expand access and awareness.

Right to education

Improvement of education system (118.153, 118.156, 118.158, 118.159, 118.160, 118.162, 118.206, 118.214, 118.215)

105. The Government, through the Ministry of Education and Training (MoET) is implementing the Education Sector Strategic Plan (ESSP) 2022–2034, which provides a comprehensive framework for strengthening education delivery across all subsectors. The ESSP aligns education reforms with national development priorities and focuses on improving learning quality, learner retention, teacher development, system coordination and sustainable financing. The plan is operationalised through the Multi-Year Action Plan (MYAP) 2022–2025 and supported through a strengthened Sector-Wide Approach (SWAp), which enhances coordination among government institutions, development partners and education stakeholders.

106. To strengthen planning, monitoring and evidence-based decision-making, the MOET has transitioned to a DHIS2-based digital Education Management Information System (EMIS). The system decentralises data collection to schools and regional levels, enabling real-time data aggregation, analysis and monitoring across primary, secondary, Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) and tertiary education. The EMIS supports tracking of national education priorities, SDG 4 indicators and key reforms under the Competency-Based Education (CBE) framework.

107. The MOET is also implementing major curriculum and structural reforms in secondary education through the introduction of a four-year secondary education structure under the CBE framework. The reform promotes learner-centred, flexible and skills-oriented learning, reduces dropouts associated with examination-driven systems, and strengthens progression pathways to tertiary education, TVET, and employment opportunities. Expanded AS/A-Level pathways and investments in ICT infrastructure, digital learning platforms and blended learning models are further supporting equitable access to education, particularly for learners in remote and resource-constrained areas. Teacher training and continuous professional development programmes are also being strengthened to support effective implementation of the new curriculum.

108. The Government continues to promote alternative education pathways and strengthen TVET through partnerships with the Commonwealth of Learning (COL), the Government of Taiwan, and the African Development Bank. These partnerships support the development of CBE and blended TVET curricula, expansion of digital learning platforms, upgrading of institutional infrastructure and equipment, and the development of occupational standards aligned with labour market needs.

109. Investment in basic education has further been strengthened through a USD 32.1 million project funded by the World Bank and the Global Partnership for Education (GPE). The project supports early childhood development, foundational literacy and numeracy, competency-based learning at primary and junior secondary levels, improved teaching of mathematics and science, teacher training, support for orphaned, vulnerable and disabled learners, and the implementation of national learning assessments to improve education quality.

110. Despite these achievements, the education sector continues to face challenges, including rising costs of education inputs due to inflation, which affect the procurement of textbooks, teaching materials and school infrastructure development. MOET is also developing regulations to operationalise the Eswatini Council of Educators in line with the Council of Educators Act, 2023, to strengthen governance, professional standards and accountability within the education sector.

111. In response to the COVID -19 pandemic, MoET, with support from development partners, implemented blended and distance learning interventions to ensure continuity of education. Curriculum-aligned lessons were delivered through national radio and television broadcasts, complemented by printed learning materials and newspaper supplements to reach learners in rural and digitally underserved communities during school closures. These interventions reached approximately 70 % of enrolled learners and supported the safe reopening of all public schools under approved health protocols.

112. Further, MoET introduced the Learning Passport, a digital platform providing continuous access to curriculum-based learning during emergencies and school disruptions. It complements radio, television and print-based learning approaches and strengthens equitable access to education. MOET is also expanding digital learning infrastructure, enhancing multi-modal content delivery, and institutionalising education emergency preparedness measures to improve resilience and ensure uninterrupted learning during future crises.

113. MOET has further supported vulnerable learners through initiatives such as the UNICEF-supported Back to School Project, which assisted learners with special educational needs following the COVID-19 pandemic.

Reintegration of pregnant learners (118.159)

114. MOET is implementing the Prevention and Management of Learner Pregnancy Policy and Guidelines (2022), which seeks to reduce learner pregnancies while increasing the number of learner-parents who complete their education. Through re-entry and continuation policies, pregnant learners and adolescent mothers are supported to return to school and continue their education without penalty. MoET has also conducted awareness campaigns targeting schools, parents and community leaders to promote the importance of continued education and compliance with compulsory schooling requirements. Due to resource constraints, Eswatini is not yet ready to provide free secondary education.

115. Despite these efforts, challenges remain, including persistent stigma against adolescent mothers and limited school-based guidance and counselling services. To address these gaps, MoET plans to strengthen counselling services, expand community sensitisation initiatives, and promote more affordable and standardised secondary school fees to improve equitable access, retention and completion of education for all learners.

Measures to address dropout rates (118.160, 118.162, 118.206)

116. Key interventions include the nationwide school feeding programme implemented in primary and secondary schools, which benefits approximately 355,478 learners and supports

school attendance and learning outcomes. MOET has also introduced early identification and intervention mechanisms through the Inclusive Education Standards to monitor learner attendance, performance and other risk indicators, enabling timely support for at-risk learners.

117. Community engagement has further been strengthened through school management committees, fostering collaboration between parents, educators and community leaders in addressing barriers to retention. In addition, the World Bank supported Strengthening Basic Education Systems Project has enhanced the Orphaned and Vulnerable Children (OVC) Education Grant system to reduce financial barriers affecting access to secondary education, thus addressing school dropouts. These combined interventions have contributed to a reduction in the national primary school dropout rate from 6.5% to 4.8%.

118. MOET commissioned an Education Sector Transformation Task Team to develop innovative means for standardising secondary school fees, which would ultimately improve equitable access to education and retention. The proposals made by the task team are currently being considered; once approved, they will be translated into a policy and action plan.

119. The MYAP, which also has a component for reducing school dropout, is also being evaluated and reviewed. Once reviewed, it will provide strengthened programmes aimed at reducing dropout rates.

Violence against children (118.210, 118.175, 180, 190, 208, 118.41)

120. The Government has centred its recovery and broader social policies on strengthening child-protection systems. The DPMO has reinforced additional social workers and community child protection committees to identify, respond to, and refer cases of violence against children. In addition, the Government guarantees access to free primary education, which serves both as a protective factor and a mechanism for early identification of abuse. Efforts are ongoing to ensure that all children, including those affected by violence, remain in or are reintegrated into the educational system.

121. The DPMO continues to conduct advocacy and community sensitisation campaigns through community meetings, traditional and digital media platforms, and school-based programmes that educate learners on harmful practices to be avoided.

122. The Ministry of Home Affairs, through its Civil Registration and Vital Statistics Department, has trained officials to detect potential forced or child marriages during the registration process of marriages. These officials conduct ongoing assessments to determine whether registered marriages comply with the constitutional requirement that marriages shall be entered into with the free and full consent of both prospective spouses.

123. For customary marriages, before solemnisation, the chiefdom sends a representative (umgijimi) to observe the process with a view to determining whether the parties are adults and they have consented to marry.

124. The Government reiterates that child marriage is explicitly prohibited under the Children's Protection and Welfare Act of 2012, and enforcement efforts continue in collaboration with traditional leaders and community structures.

125. The National Strategy and Plan of Action on Positive Parenting 2023–2027 serves as a national roadmap for attaining holistic child development by supporting and empowering parents and caregivers to discharge their parenting roles and responsibilities in the most competent and effective manner. The Strategy promotes non-violent discipline, strengthens family bonds, and aims to reduce child maltreatment by equipping parents with positive child-rearing skills. Implementation is underway in collaboration with civil society organisations, community child protection committees, and traditional leaders across the four regions of the country.

IV. New and emerging issues, including advances and challenges

126. Eswatini has advanced the human rights of persons with disabilities through the operationalisation of the National Disability Advisory Council in 2023, enhancing the implementation of the Persons with Disabilities Act. The integration of human rights and climate action is a key emerging priority, reflected in the new Disaster Risk Management Act and the development of the NDC 3.0, which adopts an inclusivity and Just Transition approach to protect vulnerable populations. Technological advances present both opportunities and challenges, with the enactment of the Computer Crime and Data Protection Acts strengthening rights in the digital sphere while requiring ongoing vigilance. A significant challenge is the persistent prevalence of GBV, demanding sustained resources and multi-sectoral coordination.

127. Additionally, while the Government is implementing several measures to improve detention conditions and reduce overcrowding, correctional facilities continue to operate at capacity significantly exceeding approved limits, indicating a need for innovative alternative forms of sentencing and crime prevention campaigns. The education sector is undergoing substantial structural reforms through the introduction of the Competency-Based Education framework and the Education Sector Strategic Plan. However, this is challenged by resource constraints, rising input costs, and persistent barriers to equitable access, retention, and completion for all learners, particularly vulnerable groups such as adolescent mothers and learners with disabilities.

V. Challenges which would require the support of the international community

128. Eswatini continues to face capacity and resource constraints in fully implementing its human rights obligations and the accepted UPR recommendations. The Government requires technical and financial support for the full operationalisation of the Legal Aid Act, the Commission on Human Rights and Public Administration Bill, and the comprehensive Family Law Bills, which are critical for strengthening institutions and aligning domestic legislation with international standards such as CEDAW.

129. Sustained support is necessary to build capacity for treaty reporting, including the development of a robust National Recommendations Tracking Database to monitor implementation. As the Government strengthens its NMRF, the cooperation of development partners remains vital for its full operationalisation. Support from the international community is also crucial for addressing social and economic challenges such as poverty reduction and food security, enhancing social protection systems, and expanding universal access to quality healthcare, education, and clean water, particularly in rural and underserved areas.

Notes

[1] https://www.gov.sz/index.php/departments-sp-654042511?view=article&id=473.